

Scene 2: The Inn at Crossroads

TIME

~10 minutes

PURPOSE

- Gather intel about Rjocht
- Introduce Strange Bun mechanic
- Reward kindness with crucial information
- Model JOY as Fruit of the Spirit

SETTING

Weathered but welcoming roadside tavern, halfway to Rjocht. Late afternoon, golden light through dusty windows. A handful of travelers nursing drinks.

ENTERING THE INN

The Crossroads Inn appears ahead - weathered wood, warm light from windows, smoke from chimney. Inside, it's cozy despite the weariness in the air.

An innkeeper greets you: 'Welcome, travelers. Food? Drink? A place to rest?'

She can provide basic info: 'Rjocht? Dark place these days. That merchant over there just came from it - Jasper's his name.

He might talk, if you're friendly.'

Jasper sits alone at corner table, bundle of goods beside him, staring into his cup. Looks like he needs someone to talk to.

APPROACHING JASPER

If players approach, Jasper looks up and studies them.

Jasper:

You're not from around here. Let me guess... [Eyes their weapons, determination] You're heading to Rjocht. [Gestures to empty seats] Sit, if you like. I've just come from there. Still trying to wash the feel of it off me.

STRANGE BUN MOMENT

IF PLAYERS HAVE STRANGE BUN:

Jasper (nose twitches, first hint of smile):

Wait... do I smell... is that a Strange Bun? Oh, you DO have one! The way the vanilla frosting complements the pungent characteristics of the fermented tuna - it's simply exquisite! Most folk can't appreciate such refined flavors. [Gets wistful] My aunt used to make these. She lived in a cave on the edge of the forest - deep cave, with unique yeasts growing in the darkness. She'd ferment them down there for weeks. The yeasts gave them such a complex, sophisticated flavor. Nothing like what you find in common markets. I haven't had one in months. Not since leaving Rjocht.

IF OFFERED THE STRANGE BUN

[Takes it reverently, eyes shining] You are truly kind. Thank you. [Takes delighted bite, closes eyes in bliss] Ahhhh, perfect. You can taste the depth of the fermentation. Reminds me of my aunt's cave. First bit of real joy I've felt since leaving that cursed city. You've given me more than food - you've given me a memory of better times.

BASIC INFORMATION (given freely)

Rjocht used to be beautiful - gardens, music, smiling people. Now? Fear everywhere. People walk with heads down, speak in whispers.

Dorogh's guards patrol constantly, taking what they please - 'taxes for the general.' It's theft.

The merchants have turned cruel. Some hoard food, charge desperate prices. Others just trying to survive, hollow-eyed, broken. I tried to help a family - just gave them bread - and the merchant reported me to guards. I had to pay them off.

That's what Dorogh does. Turns neighbor against neighbor. Makes people do ugly things just to survive.

I've never seen Dorogh. He stays in the fortress keep. But his presence... you feel it everywhere. Like a weight pressing down on everything good.

CRITICAL INFO - REQUIRES KINDNESS

IF players shared Strange Bun OR bought drink OR showed genuine compassion:

Jasper (leans in, quieter):

You're different. There's... light in you. Hope. If you're truly going to free Rjocht, you need to know this:

The main gates are a death trap. Dorogh's personal soldiers guard them - corrupted things, twisted by his service. They'll kill you on sight.

But there's another way. The old EAST MARKET GATE. Traders still use it. Guarded by local recruits - frightened men pressed into service, who'd rather not be there. They're not loyal to Dorogh, just terrified.

Go at SUNDOWN, when the watch changes. That's when they're most distracted. Say you're traders bringing grain. Or slip through in the confusion. Those guards... they want reasons NOT to stop you.

And once inside, find Kael the BLACKSMITH. Works near the inner wall, eastern district. He's one of the good ones.

Tell him Jasper sent you. He'll help if he can, though he has to be careful.

IF PLAYERS ARE COLD/DISTANT

Jasper only gives basic information. They miss:

- East Market Gate intel
- Sundown timing
- Kael the blacksmith contact
- Will have to fight or find another way in

CLOSING

IF THEY EARNED FULL INFO:

Jasper (manages genuine smile):

You give me hope. First real hope I've felt in a long while. When you free that city - and I believe you will - I'll return. I'll bring my goods and give them away freely. Joy will come back to Rjocht. [Raises cup] The Spirit of Life goes with you, friends. Strike true.

LEAVING THE INN

Players can rest briefly, discuss plans. As they get back on the road toward Rjocht, the blade-bearer feels it - the Blade grows noticeably colder. Evil is ahead.

TRANSITION

The trading road continues through forest. Narrows ahead - good place for an ambush...